

Spillover Threat

■ In the run up to the Indian elections, terror attacks may go up as instability in Pakistan may embolden terrorist groups to strike at India.

■ A Mumbai-style attack just before the elections could bring the countries to the brink of war.

■ India wants US to put pressure on General Kayani to stop using terrorism as an instrument of state policy.

certainly a heightened level of threat which requires greater preparedness on our part," said a senior South Block official.

Besides, with internal trouble brewing in Pakistan, these jihadi groups may mushroom. India's concerns also stem from the fact that, as the Pakistan Government's agreement with the Pakistan Taliban in the Swat Valley indicates, extremists would have the upper hand and the new political matrix in Islamabad may embolden terrorist groups to strike at India. Analysts fear that a terror strike in India just before the elections may provoke a strong response from India and may bring the two countries to the brink of war.

India has already voiced its concerns behind closed doors. Last week when Foreign Secretary Shivshankar Menon met US Secretary of State Hillary Clinton and the US National Security Adviser General John Jones, they were told that the key lies in sending a strong message to General Kayani that the Pakistan Army has to shed its policy of promot-

threat of the growing Taliban as a fig leaf to delay the Mumbai investigations. To counter this, India has also suggested that the US should seek deportation of the Mumbai terror suspects detained by Pakistan; it could as the FBI has registered a case in the US because six of its nationals died in the attacks.

Delhi realises that it cannot let the issue die down, and that Pakistan should not take the plea that India is not cooperating. That explains the six-page-long reply to Pakistan's questions and a 390-page annexure both of which were vetted in a fine toothcomb-like manner by Home Minister P. Chidambaram, who also is a lawyer. India wants to ensure that Pakistan does not find an excuse to delay the investigation. But Islamabad seems to be resorting to old games. It had dispatched two more questions in addition to the 30 it had sent to India, which gave away its double game. It sought permission for Pakistani investigators to question an eyewitness in the Hemant Karkare killing; it had also sought information

INDIA'S LAUNDRY LIST OF CONCERNS REMAINS—WITH NO CLEAR CENTRE OF POWER, WHO TO DO BUSINESS WITH IN PAKISTAN?



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ing terrorism as an instrument of state policy. Menon also conveyed another concern that India has—that Pakistan may try to sidestep the Mumbai investigations on some pretext or the other. A fear, many experts echo. "Weakening of Zardari will mean that the Mumbai investigations may be interminably stalled," feels Parthasarthy.

"Political instability would reduce the chances of any co-operation on the Mumbai attacks investigation," says Amitabh Mattoo, former vice-chancellor of the University of Jammu. Pakistan's past record is also suspect and has added to the apprehension that Islamabad may use the political uncertainty and the

on the alleged role played by a Surat-based diamond merchant in the Mumbai attacks.

While Delhi has given it the statement of the eyewitness, it described Pakistan's 32nd question as a 'figment of imagination'. Initial reports too suggest that Pakistan is not enthused by India's response. However, New Delhi is unfazed and may ratchet up international pressure in coming days. The issue would figure prominently when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh meets US President Barack Obama on April 2 in London on the margins of the G-20 summit. The US too realises that this shouldn't trigger another round of Indo-Pak brinkmanship, so it has reiterated its support. It has also communicated that FBI officials would depose against Kasab in Mumbai. The US may allay India's concerns to some extent but more would be required. India would need another round of concerted pressure on Pakistan, to ensure its immediate concerns are met and it is not saddled with, as one expert put it, "a nuclear Somalia in its neighbourhood". ■